Self-checking

Teaching students to improve their own work

Use self-checking when students know what quality looks like but do not yet inspect their own work reliably. Teach a specific checking action rather than telling them to “check it”.

How to do it well

1 Select the checking focus. Choose a consequential feature students have been taught and can recognise.

2 Demonstrate the check. Think aloud while inspecting a model and identifying a near-miss.

3 Rehearse on shared work. Students locate the feature or error in an example before moving to their own response.

4 Apply and improve. Require a visible checking action and an explained correction, rather than silent rereading alone.

5 Transfer the routine. Use the same checking question on a fresh task, then reduce the external prompt when students can apply it reliably.

What this sounds like

“Underline your claim and circle the evidence. Draw an arrow where the sentence explains how the evidence supports the claim. Which link is missing?”

Classroom example. In Science, pupils check the units in their calculations using a taught sequence: identify the quantity, inspect the substitution and inspect the final unit. They correct and explain a mismatch, then use the routine on another question. A generic instruction to check the whole page would have provided less guidance about the thinking required.

Top tips that make the technique work

Teach what to inspect. Specify a claim–evidence link, sign, unit or process decision rather than an unlimited search.

Use a model and a near-miss. Students need to see the feature present and absent before finding it in their own work.

Separate checking from rereading. A purposeful check asks a question of the work and may require recalculation, comparison or evidence tracing.

Give one checking focus first. Build fluency before expecting a long checklist to be used independently.

Check the checker. Sample how students located and repaired the issue; a tick beside a criterion is not evidence of accurate self-assessment.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Model the checking process and require a visible action.	“Check your work” with no taught process.
Fade prompts as checking becomes reliable.	Assuming every self-awarded tick is accurate.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation. Some links support part of this guide rather than the whole technique.

DistillED - Feedback as Detective Work